# Chapter 25

# Common errors

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APPENDIX · COMMON ERRORS

A field guide to the R, Quarto, and `renv` errors that will bite you first.

Each entry lists the error message, the usual cause, and the fix that works most of the time.

## 25.1 R

**Error:** `thereisnopackagecalled'xyz'`

*Cause:* the package is not installed in the library R is looking in.

*Fix:* `install.packages("xyz")`. If you are using `renv`, run `renv::restore()` instead to keep the lock file authoritative.

**Error:** `couldnotfindfunction"ggplot"`

*Cause:* package is installed but not loaded.

*Fix:* `library(ggplot2)` (or `library(tidyverse)`).

**Error:** `non-finitevaluesuppliedbyoptim`

*Cause:* the model failed to converge, often because of extreme starting values, perfect separation (logistic regression), or a misspecified formula.

*Fix:* rescale predictors, use sensible starting values, or for logistic regression check for zero cells in the outcome-by-predictor table.

**Error:** `contrastscanbeappliedonlytofactorswith2ormorelevels`

*Cause:* a factor predictor has been filtered down to a single level.

*Fix:* check `table(your_data$predictor)` and restore levels, or drop that predictor from the model.

**Error:** `ErrorinUseMethod("predict"):noapplicablemethodfor'predict'applied toanobjectofclass"c('list')"`

*Cause:* you passed the wrong object to `predict()`. Usually a list instead of the fitted model.

*Fix:* check the object with `class()` and pass the model object itself, e.g. `predict(fit,newdata=nd)`.

**Error:** `Loadingrequiredpackage:foo—thereisnopackagecalled'foo'`

*Cause:* an installed package has a dependency that is missing.

*Fix:* `install.packages("foo",dependencies=TRUE)`.

## 25.2 Quarto

**Error:** `quarto:commandnotfound`

*Cause:* Quarto is not on your PATH.

*Fix:* install from https://quarto.org and restart your terminal. On macOS, check that `/usr/local/bin` (or the Homebrew prefix) is in your PATH.

**Error:** `Failedtorender:yoursystemismissingpandoc`

*Cause:* older versions of R Quarto missed the bundled pandoc.

*Fix:* upgrade Quarto to the latest release.

**Error:** `Errorrunningfiltershortcodes`

*Cause:* a Quarto extension is missing after cloning.

*Fix:* run `quartoadd` for the extension, or ignore if the extension is optional.

**Error:** `outputfile:docs/index.htmldoesnotexist`

*Cause:* `quartorender` was interrupted or `output-dir` changed.

*Fix:* re-run `quartorender` from a clean state; if the interruption wedged `.quarto/`, delete that cache directory and try again.

**Error:** `GitHubPagesdeploymentfailed:404`

*Cause:* Pages is pointing at the wrong branch or path.

*Fix:* in the repo Settings → Pages, select the `gh-pages` branch and the `/(root)` folder. Our workflow deploys to `gh-pages` by default.

## 25.3 renv

**Error:** `renv::restore()failedwith:cannotinstallpackage'xyz'fromsource`

*Cause:* a system library is missing. The error above this line usually names the header file.

*Fix:* install the matching `-dev` package on Linux, the corresponding Homebrew package on macOS, or Rtools on Windows. Common culprits:

- `libcurl4-openssl-dev` for `curl`
- `libxml2-dev` for `XML` / `xml2`
- `libssl-dev` for `openssl`
- `libfontconfig1-dev`, `libfreetype6-dev`, `libharfbuzz-dev`, `libfribidi-dev` for `systemfonts`, `ragg`, `textshaping`
- `libgit2-dev` for `gert`

**Error:** `renvisoutofsyncwiththelockfile`

*Cause:* the project library differs from `renv.lock`.

*Fix:* `renv::status()` to see what, then `renv::restore()` to synchronise.

## 25.4 knitr / rmarkdown

**Error:** `pandocdocumentconversionfailedwitherror2`

*Cause:* YAML front matter is malformed — often an unquoted colon in a title.

*Fix:* quote the offending string. `title:"Two:peasinapod"`.

**Error:** `Errorinchunkname:object'xyz'notfound`

*Cause:* an earlier chunk was skipped or cached stale.

*Fix:* clear the knitr cache (`knitr::clean_cache()`) and re-render; check chunk evaluation with `eval=TRUE`.

## 25.5 Git

**Error:** `fatal:refusingtomergeunrelatedhistories`

*Cause:* you cloned one repo and then tried to pull from a different initialisation.

*Fix:* only run `gitpull--allow-unrelated-histories` if you are sure you want to merge.

**Error:** `Permissiondenied(publickey)`

*Cause:* your SSH key is not registered with GitHub.

*Fix:* add your key via Settings → SSH and GPG keys, or switch the remote to HTTPS: `gitremoteset-urloriginhttps://github.com/...`.